Balak 5784

פרשת בלק is one of the most fascinating פרשיות in the entire תורה. It discusses the נבואות of בלעם, the fact that בלעם, a רשע, became a נביא for the גוים, and his failed attempts to bring a קללה on כלל ישראל.The sefer אור גדליהו, a wonderful sefer which I encourage everyone to get (if it's available), has the following vort on פרשת בלק. The מהר"ל דיסקין is quoted in the אור גדליהו, quoting a רש"י in ד"ה עמוד ב מסכתא בבא בתרא דף י. The גמרא says מֹשֶׁה כָּתַב סִפְרוֹ וּפָרָשַׁת בִּלְעָם וְאִיּוֹב - Moshe wrote his sefer, which is חמשה חומשי תורה, the פרשה of בלעם, and ספר איוב.

Rashi asks why is the גמרא giving this distinction to the פרשה of בלעם? Rashi answers: שפרשת בלעם אינה כשאר התורה שאינה אלא נבואתו ומשליו של בלעם - The story of בלעם is not like the rest of the Torah, rather, it's בלעם's prophecy and parables. All the מפרשים struggle with this enigmatic Rashi, which is saying that the פרשה of בלעם is not like the rest of the תורה. Now we know that every single פסוק in the תורה, whether it's the עשרת הדברות or the יחוס brief of עשו הרשע, every word of the תורה has קדושה, the same exact level of קדושה as every other word in the תורה. So what could Rashi possibly be meaning here? That's one קשיא.

The second קשיא is also fundamental: we know that בלעם was given the job, was requested by בלק to curse כלל ישראל. בלעם said to all of בלק's messengers, "I can't go unless Hashem lets me go." Finally Hashem said, "If they tell you to go, go", and בלעם couldn't wait to go, he even saddled his own donkey. Now, בלעם obviously knew הקדוש ברוך הוא did not want him to curse כלל ישראל. So what was his אמינא הוה? What was he thinking? Did he really believe he could override the will of Hashem, חס ושלום? Hashem said to him clearly (22:12), לֹא תָאֹר אֶת הָעָם כִּי בָרוּךְ הוּא, and he went anyway. How could he possibly have felt that he could have been successful?

There's a long discussion about what the concept of נבואה is. It's beyond the scope of this short presentation to give you all of it, but we know that משה רבינו was considered the נביא par excellence, as opposed to all other נביאים. Hashem spoke to all the other נביאים through a certain channel called אספקלריא. For lack of a better term, we'll translate that as a piece of glass. So it's brought down by רב גדליה that every one of the נביאים was able to see הקדוש ברוך הוא based on the level of קדושה of his own נשמה. In other words, the נבואה was channeled through the נביא's נשמה and came out from the נביא through the conduit, through the channel of his נשמה, as through colored glass. Moshe's level of קדושה was on such a high מדרגה that it's called אספקלריא המאירה. It was comparable to a clear piece of glass. There was some sort of partition, some separation, because he was a בשר ודם. But his level of נבואה was on such a high מדרגה that it was considered אספקלריא המאירה, that there was nothing that was getting in the way of הקדוש ברוך הוא's message and the נבואה as it was transmitted. The famous example he brings out from the מדרש is that אברהם אבינו was a נביא, was on a very high level of נבואה, but אברהם אבינו called himself אנכי עפר ואפר. He still had some ממשות to him. He was still something, even though he considered himself nothing. משה רבינו on the other hand was נחנו מה. We are [speaking of himself and אהרן] nothing. So vis-a-vis הקדוש ברוך הוא's message there was no impediment getting in the way.

בלעם knew that his level of נבואה was channeled through his "נשמה", through his level of טומאה, and it came out in a very krum, distorted way because that's the kind of person he was. He thought that he could pull this off by having his נבואה come through his level of טהרה, or lack thereof, of his נשמה, and he would be able to give a קללה through that. However, הקדוש ברוך הוא gave him an unmatched, unrivaled gift. הקדוש ברוך הוא gave בלעם the level of נבואה of משה רבינו for this period of time. As we all know, the מדרש says, לא קם נביא בישראל כמשה - There was no נביא in ישראל like משה, but amongst the גוים there was בלעם. How can we possibly understand that מדרש? This answers that.

Yes, בלעם was a רשע. Yes, בלעם was טמא. Yes, בלעם was the lowest of the low. But in order to prevent any קללה on בלעם's part, הקדוש ברוך הוא gave this unparalleled gift of the level of נבואה of משה רבינו, so that when he said his נבואה, it came out exactly in the same way as משה רבינו's level of נבואה. That being the case he was forced against his will to give the נבואה properly and give כלל ישראל that ברכה.

https://youtu.be/d3mEJDo7OX0

So when we say that משה רבינו wrote the entire תורה and the פרשה of בלעם, Moshe took the נבואות of all the other נביאים, אברהם, יצחק, יעקב, or anybody else that's mentioned in the תורה, and transmitted it through his level of קדושה, which was on an unparalleled level, so that the תורה is called תורת משה. All of their נבואות were elevated, as it were, to the level of משה רבינו, except for one: except for בלעם. It didn't require elevation, because it was already elevated.

That's what Rashi, according to the אור גדליהו, is intimating: to the fact הקדוש ברוך הוא gave בלעם this unbelievable gift of being able to receive נבואה just like משה רבינו. That's why משה רבינו didn't have to write the פרשה of בלעם on his level, it was already written that way. He was just copying it from what was already there, from how it was brought down from בלעם himself.

This gives us a small inkling of what is going on in this world vis-a-vis the next world. Each one of us has a נשמה. Part of it is connected to us, part of it is connected to הקדוש ברוך הוא. The more that we raise our נשמה in levels of קדושה, the more we bring our נשמה closer to הקדוש ברוך הוא. Moshe did it perfectly, and it shows. All the other נביאים did it almost perfectly, and it shows. We are so far away from this whole concept, we don't even know about it, and maybe this is a good chance for us to even get an inkling as to what's going on here. So our work is cut out for us. It's our job to keep on perfecting to the best of our limited abilities that which הקדוש ברוך הוא gave us as a gift and make ourselves into true עבדי השם.

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